

Student Lesson: Marketplace Models — What Changes at Different Ages?

Course 17: Skills That Pay — Lesson 6

What You'll Learn Today

By now in Course 17, you've practiced describing a skill, pricing your work, and pitching yourself. This lesson takes a step back and looks at a different question: **why do online marketplaces treat users differently depending on how old they are, and what does that actually mean for someone your age?**

We're going to study four real platforms — Fiverr, Upwork, Etsy, and Gumroad — as **case studies**, the same way you'd study four different countries' laws in a social studies class. We are not signing up for any of them today. This is about understanding how these systems are built, not about joining one.

Why Do Marketplaces Have Age Rules at All?

It's not random. There are usually three real reasons behind it:

1. **Contracts and the law.** When you use a marketplace, you're agreeing to a legal contract (the Terms of Service). In most places, someone under 18 has limited legal ability to enter into contracts on their own. That's a real legal fact, not a company being difficult.
2. **Money and payments.** Getting paid through a platform usually involves banking and tax rules that are built around adults holding accounts. Someone has to be legally responsible for the money.
3. **Safety.** Marketplaces often involve messaging between strangers who don't know each other in real life. Platforms build in extra protection — like requiring a parent or guardian to be involved — because of that.

Different companies solve these problems in different ways. That's exactly what we're comparing today.

Case Study: Four Platforms, Four Models

Important caveat before you read this table: these are real, general policies as commonly described at the time this lesson was written. **Companies change their Terms of Service.** If you ever seriously consider using one of these platforms, you must check that platform's *current* policy yourself — do not rely on a class handout from a past lesson.

Platform	How it generally handles minors (13–17)	What's required
Fiverr	Can be used by 13–17 year-olds only through an account that is owned and managed by a parent or legal guardian. Full adult terms apply once you reach the age of majority (commonly 18).	A parent/guardian must own and control the account.
Upwork	Does not allow use by anyone under 18, or under the age of majority in their country if that's different from 18.	You must be an adult (by your local law) to use it at all.
Etsy	Can be used by 13–17 year-olds only through a shop account owned and operated by a parent or legal guardian.	A parent/guardian must own and control the account.
Gumroad	Age requirements, guardian involvement, and whether you can even receive payouts depend on your country and personal circumstances — there isn't one single global rule.	You'd need to check current, country-specific policy.

Notice the pattern: two platforms (Fiverr, Etsy) build a path for younger teens *through* a parent or guardian's account. One platform (Upwork) simply says adults only. One platform (Gumroad) says "it depends where you live." None of these are wrong — they're just different business and legal choices.

What We Do NOT Teach

This is important, so we're going to say it plainly:

Lumexa never teaches, suggests, or endorses misrepresenting your age or bypassing an age requirement on any platform. Doing that can get an account permanently banned (along with any money in it), violates the platform's terms, and in some situations can create real legal problems. If a platform requires you to be a certain age, or requires a parent/guardian-owned account, the responsible path is either to wait, to involve a parent or guardian, or to choose a different avenue — never to lie about it.

This lesson exists so you *understand* these systems, not so you can find a way around them.

Key Terms

- **Age of majority** — the age at which the law considers someone a legal adult, able to enter contracts on their own. It's 18 in most places you're likely to encounter, but it can differ by country.
- **Guardian-owned account** — an account that is legally held and controlled by a parent or legal guardian, even if a minor's work happens through it.
- **Terms of Service (ToS)** — the legal agreement you accept when you use a platform. It's a real contract, which is exactly why age and contract-capacity rules matter.
- **Payout** — the actual transfer of earned money from a platform to a person's bank account or payment method; often has its own separate rules about who can receive it.

Knowledge Check (5 Questions)

1. Name two real-world reasons (not "just because") that marketplaces set different rules for minors versus adults.
2. Which two platforms studied today use a "parent/guardian-owned account" model for 13–17 year-olds?
3. True or False: Upwork allows 16-year-olds to use the platform on their own, without an adult. Explain your answer.
4. Why does Gumroad's policy depend on "country and circumstances" rather than being one single global age?
5. If a classmate said, "I'll just put in a fake birthdate so the site lets me sign up," what would you say to them, based on today's lesson?

Reflection Prompts (Choose or Answer All 3)

1. Of the models we studied today (guardian-owned account vs. 18+-only vs. varies-by-country), which one do you think makes the most sense for someone your age, and why?
2. Think of a skill or product you might want to sell someday. Based on today's lesson, what real step (not a workaround) would you need to take before you could sell it through a platform like these?
3. Why do you think it matters that these rules can change over time? What would you do differently *because* they can change, compared to if they were fixed forever?

Submission Instructions

- Complete your Knowledge Check answers and Reflection responses in your Google Doc or Notion page for this lesson.
- Complete the accompanying Worksheet (Marketplace Model Comparison) and attach it to the same submission.
- Submit by sharing your Notion page link with your instructor, or emailing your completed doc to your instructor, per your class's usual submission method.
- Submissions are due before the next live class session unless your instructor states otherwise.